

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 687

By Love

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Dr. William E. Arnold, Jr.,
for his contributions to the State of Tennessee.

WHEREAS, it is our privilege to specially recognize those estimable individuals who, through their extraordinary efforts, have distinguished themselves as community leaders of whom we can all be proud; and

WHEREAS, one such noteworthy person is Dr. William E. Arnold, Jr., a highly respected individual who has dedicated himself to justice and community empowerment; and

WHEREAS, in 2013, Dr. William Arnold was wrongfully convicted in Nashville; his conviction was unanimously overturned by the Tennessee Court of Criminal Appeals in 2020, making him the first individual to receive relief from the Davidson County Conviction Review Unit; and

WHEREAS, April 15, 2025, marks the fifth anniversary of Dr. Arnold's exoneration, a powerful milestone that symbolizes the triumph of truth, the promise of second chances, and the enduring strength of the human spirit; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Arnold has since transformed his experience into purpose, using his platform to promote labor-focused reentry strategies that restore dignity, reduce recidivism, and build equitable workforce opportunities for justice-involved individuals; and

WHEREAS, a native of Memphis, Dr. Arnold is the founder and diversity compliance officer of Arnold Diversity Consulting in Memphis, which engages organizations in an effort to effect culture change, organizational development, and process improvement; and

WHEREAS, he also currently serves as director of the Tennessee Office of Reentry within the Department of Labor and Workforce Development, the first comprehensive, state-funded, non-Department-of-Correction-affiliated reentry office in the nation; and

WHEREAS, in this capacity, he has spearheaded initiatives that provide formerly incarcerated individuals with job training, housing support, and mentorship; his leadership has directly impacted families, reduced recidivism, and strengthened communities by fostering pathways to stability and success, and his work has given thousands of returning citizens not only a second chance but a renewed sense of hope and purpose; and

WHEREAS, prior to serving as director of the Tennessee Office of Reentry, Dr. Arnold was on the transition team of Shelby County District Attorney Steve Mulroy and chaired the subcommittee that established the Shelby County Justice Review Unit, the second such unit in the State of Tennessee focused on criminal justice reform and accountability; and

WHEREAS, his previous posts further include serving as director of Division Access, Diversity, and Equity for the Tennessee Board of Regents and director of Academic Programs and Interagency Grants for the Tennessee Higher Education Commission; and

WHEREAS, Dr. William Arnold is a TED Talk alumnus and highly respected national speaker; he holds a bachelor's degree in sociology from the University of Tennessee and a Master of Education degree in Administration and Supervision and an Ed.D. in higher education administration from Tennessee State University; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Arnold epitomizes the spirit and commitment that are characteristic of a true Tennessean; and

WHEREAS, it is most fitting that we acknowledge and applaud this esteemed gentleman; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Dr. William E. Arnold, Jr., for his remarkable journey of resilience, advocacy, and leadership, extending our gratitude for his commitment to advancing justice, equity, and opportunity for the citizens of this State.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.